

THE STRUCTURE OF MATHEMATICAL REALITY

Phase I — Chapter 2

What Numbers Actually Are

Assignment

Self-Study Curriculum

Write a one-page explanation of what numbers are, addressed to yourself six months ago. Do not use any jargon that you have not defined. The explanation should cover: (a) why “numbers are things you count with” is inadequate, (b) what numbers actually are in the structural sense, and (c) why there are different number systems rather than just one.

The test of quality: could you hand this to a colleague with your background and have them understand something they did not understand before?